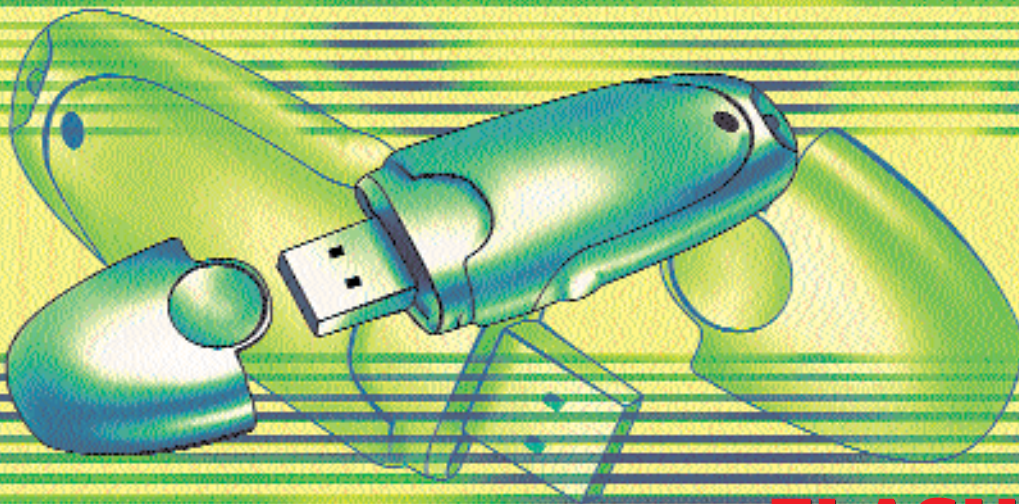




FLASH DRIVES

How many of us use floppy drives and floppies? We wouldn't be too presumptuous in saying that people don't even think of buying one today. People mostly transfer files via the Internet using e-mail. If you do not have an Internet connection, you should consider investing in a Flash drive instead of using floppies or even rewritable CDs.

Flash drives are not only convenient to use, but also much faster, more reliable, and have far greater capacities than floppies. 'Chewing gum stick'-sized pen drives are durable (if used properly), and large capacity drives (1 GB and above) can be used to store personal information when using a shared computer. Current generation BIOSes also support booting from a USB Flash drive.

Questions to ask the dealer

Will the Flash drive work on Windows 98 and Linux?

Flash drives require a mass storage class driver. This driver class is included in Windows ME, Windows 2000 and Windows XP by default. So, users will have to download the driver for Windows 98 from the manufacturer's site. The USB Flash driver will work in the Linux operating system running kernel 2.4.6 and above. You may have to

mount the partition if it is not auto-mounted.

Is the Flash drive bootable?

For booting through a Flash drive, the BIOS must have the option to boot such a device—check your motherboard manual. Moreover, the device itself should support 'bootability'; consult the dealer before you assume this support. If this option is supported, the manufacturer will provide the necessary tools to make the drive bootable.

What type of warranty, if any, is preferable?

Warranties differ between manufacturers. Local manufacturers may or may not provide a warranty, but the known brands do. If price is not an issue, opt for a good brand that offers a replacement warranty of at least one year.

Interesting Facts

A USB Flash drive is made up of a NAND-gate circuitry-based Flash memory (a form of EEPROM) integrated with USB 1.1 or 2.0 interface. A Flash drive derives the power for its operation from the host USB port. A USB Flash drive has several names, including "Pen drive," "Thumb drive," "USB key," and more.

IBM invented the Flash drive way back in 1998 as a replacement for floppy drives in their ThinkPad line of products, but they never patented it! In the

year 2004, WIZO (pronounced Vee-Zoh), a German punk-rock band, was the first artist to release music in MP3 format on a USB drive titled the "WIZO Stick-EP".

Usage Tips

■ Always cover the USB connector of your Flash drive with the cover provided



by the manufacturer in order to protect it from damage.

■ When removing the Flash drive from the USB port, always un-mount the drive, that is, use the 'Safely remove device' option that Windows provides.

■ Use write-protect, if available, with your drive to avoid accidental overwrite or deletion of data.

■ If you are using some kind of security tool, be careful not lose your password.

The Future

In order to reduce the overall cost of Flash drives, semiconductor corporations are working on integrating many features into a single chip. Lower capacity Flash drives are being phased out.

The U3 platform has been designed to transform a simple Flash drive into a USB smart drive; for this, the applications used also have to be U3 compliant. A U3 smart drive enables a user to carry not only his or her data, but also applications that can be used on any machine, without the need to actually install those applications. ■

Points To Ponder

Do I need a Flash drive?

Flash drives are meant for those who work regularly on two or more computers. These drives come in a variety of capacities. The primary need of a Flash drive is to transport data from one PC to another. Choose one considering the maximum size of data that you may have to carry around. If you only need to carry around a few small documents, you could, of course, e-mail them back and

forth between, say, work and home. Again, if you don't have a reliable Net connection, consider buying a Flash drive!

Are there many manufacturers for this kind of product?

Yes. Of the companies that sell Flash drives, there are some who contribute to the development of the technology, and some are local marketing companies. It is advisable to buy a Flash drive from a recognised brand.